Grade 5 ELA Reading: Test Blueprint and Specifications

A sample development package: form blueprint, passage specifications, and an item specification

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Aligned to CCSS ELA, adaptable to state standards

PART 1 Test Blueprint

A short form with two passage sets: a literary set, The Praline Pot, and an informational set, The Secret Life of Sugar Crystals. The form totals **16 items and 20 points**, administered in about 50 minutes.

ITEM MAP BY REPORTING CATEGORY

Reporting category	Standard	Item	Item type	DOK	Difficulty	Points
Reading Literature (Set A: The Praline Pot) Published						**8**
	RL.5.3	A2	Multiple choice	2	Medium	1
	RL.5.2 / RL.5.1	A3	Two-part EBSR	3	Hard	2
	RL.5.2	A4	TE: drag and drop	2	Medium	1
	RL.5.2 / RL.5.1	A5	TE: hot text	2	Medium	1
	RL.5.5	A6	Multiple choice	3	Hard	1
	RL.5.3 / W.5.9a	A8	Short constructed response	3	Hard	2
Reading Informational Text (Set B: The Secret Life of Sugar Crystals) Published						**8**
	RI.5.2	B2	Two-part EBSR (main ideas)	3	Hard	2
	RI.5.3	B3	TE: drag and drop (cause and effect)	2	Medium	1
	RI.5.5	B4	Multiple choice (text structure)	3	Hard	1
	RI.5.8	B5	TE: hot text (reasons and evidence)	2	Medium	1
	RI.5.1	B6	Multiple choice (inference)	2	Medium	1
	RI.5.2 / W.5.9b	B8	Short constructed response	3	Hard	2
Vocabulary and Language (both sets)						**4**
	L.5.4a / RL.5.4	A1	Multiple choice (context clues)	1	Easy	1
	L.5.5a / RL.5.4	A7	Multiple choice (simile)	2	Medium	1
	L.5.4a / RI.5.4	B1	Multiple choice (domain-specific word)	1	Easy	1
	L.5.4b	B7	Multiple choice (Greek or Latin root)	1	Easy	1
Form total: 16 items						**20**

Item IDs match the published sets (A1 = G5-LIT-PP-01; B1 = G5-INF-SC-01; and so on).

FORM TARGETS

Points by reporting category

Literature	■■■■	8 (40%)
Informational	■■■■	8 (40%)
Vocabulary	■■	4 (20%)

Points by Depth of Knowledge

DOK 1	■	3 (15%)
DOK 2	■■■■	7 (35%)
DOK 3	■■■■■	10 (50%)

Points by item type

Multiple choice	■■■■	8 (40%)
Two-part EBSR	■■	4 (20%)
Tech-enhanced	■■	4 (20%)
Constructed resp.	■■	4 (20%)

Constraint	Target	This form
Literary to informational balance (grade 4 to 5, per CCSS guidance)	50 / 50 of reading points	8 / 8 points, plus 2 vocabulary points per set
Difficulty mix (items)	About 20% easy, 45% medium, 35% hard	3 easy (19%), 7 medium (44%), 6 hard (37%)
Machine-scored points	At least 75%	16 of 20 points (80%)
Key balance (multiple choice and EBSR parts)	No key letter above 35%; no more than 3 in a row	12 keys: A 3, B 3, C 3, D 3; no letter more than twice in a row
Clueing and overlap	No item answers or hints at another item	Reviewed across both sets; topics pair, but no tested content overlaps

PART 2 Passage Specifications

Requirements every grade 5 passage must meet before items are written.

Element	Literary passages	Informational passages
Length	500 to 800 words	450 to 750 words; may include one simple graphic
Quantitative complexity	740L to 1010L (CCSS grades 4 to 5 band), confirmed with a licensed Lexile measure; screening estimates from the Readability Analyzer	
Qualitative complexity	At least one of: implied theme, figurative language, character change, shifts in time	At least one of: implied main idea, multiple main ideas, cause-and-effect or compare-contrast structure, domain vocabulary defined in context
Item capacity	Supports at least 8 independent items across at least 5 standards, plus one constructed response, without items overlapping	
Source and rights	Original commissioned text or a permissioned published text; full rights for print, online, and accommodated forms (read-aloud, braille, translation)	
Accuracy	Realistic details are plausible and internally consistent	Every fact verified against two credible sources and documented in a fact-check log
Fairness and sensitivity	Represents people and communities accurately and without stereotype; avoids graphic violence, disturbing content, and topics likely to upset students during testing; requires no regional, cultural, or economic background to understand; regional terms glossed and not tested	
Format	Numbered paragraphs; title and byline; no more than three glossed words; works with text-to-speech and screen readers	

PART 3

Item Specification: RL.5.3

The guidance item writers receive for one standard.

Standard	RL.5.3: Compare and contrast two or more characters, settings, or events in a story or drama, drawing on specific details in the text (for example, how characters interact).
Evidence statements	• The student identifies similarities or differences between two characters, settings, or events using details from the text. • The student explains how a character's actions or feelings differ at two points in the story. • The student describes how two characters interact and uses details to support the description.
Item types and points	Multiple choice (1); two-part EBSR (2); hot text (1); short constructed response (2)
Depth of Knowledge	DOK 2 for single comparisons; DOK 3 when students must synthesize details across the text or explain a change
Stimulus requirements	A literary passage with at least two developed characters, or one character shown in at least two contrasting scenes or events
Sample stems	• How is [character]'s approach in paragraphs [x] to [y] different from [his/her] approach in paragraphs [x] to [y]? • How are [character A] and [character B] alike? • Which detail best shows how [character A] and [character B] interact? • Part A: How does [character] change? Part B: Which detail best supports the answer to Part A?
Key and distractor rules	• The key states a comparison supported by details from both sides of the comparison. • Distractors may: reverse the comparison; describe only one side; use an accurate detail from the wrong point in the story; or state a difference the text does not support. • Options name specific actions or traits, not vague labels such as "nice" or "different."
Exclusions	• Comparisons across two different texts (assess with RL.5.9). • Items that only ask for a theme or a summary (assess with RL.5.2). • Items that require knowledge from outside the passage, or that ask students to judge a character's culture or family.
Accessibility	Paragraph references in every stem; plain syntax; options parallel in length; hot text segments of complete sentences; keyboard operation for all technology-enhanced formats
Exemplars	The Praline Pot, Items 2 and 8; the revised item in the AI item-review case study

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